Between the citadel and the middle town is an open field, 285 m x 47 m, which was once enclosed on all four sides by stepped grandstands, in either three of four tiers. The space has been dubbed a ‘stadium’, which Bisht reckons may be the ‘earliest and the largest stadium found so far in antiquity’.[14] Besides sports, the ‘stadium’ may also have hosted ‘royal’ or religious ceremonies, festivals, public executions, performances or markets.



Figure 5. ‘Citadel’ and north gate, overlooking the ‘stadium’



Figure 6. Symbols on the signboard of Dholavira. Author of sketch: Siyajkak; CC BY-SA 3.0

Overlooking this stadium is the citadel’s north gate, the most monumental of all gates. Perhaps big announcements were made from its high vantage point to thousands of people gathered below. On this gate hung the famous three-metre-wide signboard of Dholavira, with its ten mysterious symbols. Each symbol, made from gypsum inlaid in wood, was